several painters, ‘I can discover which face is the work of each of them. If any other person has put in the eye and eyebrow of a face, I can perceive whose work the original face is, and who has painted the eye and eyebrow.’

The images showcased the unfettered brilliance of artists at the peak of their powers and an empire at its most capacious in terms of wealth and ambition. The manuscripts were treasured and kept within the imperial library, to be handled with care and admired by each successive emperor.

These tiny, jewel-bright manuscripts were a new direction for the Mughal taswir khanas but the translation projects begun at Fatehpur Sikri also continued in Lahore. The first Persian translation of the other famous Hindustani epic, the Ramayan, was undertaken at this time. This was the first illustrated manuscript of the epic. Earlier Rajput versions, if they had existed, would have been destroyed in the storming of Chittor and Gwalior, the major centres of art at that time. The Mughals understood the epic to be about the trials and tribulations of an ideal Indian monarch, Ram. This had great resonance with Akbar, who rather enjoyed the frequent comparisons that Brahmins made between Vishnu and the Padshah. Badauni had long lamented that Brahmins had told Akbar ‘that he had descended to earth, like Ram, Krishan, and other infidel rulers’. The particular attributes that Akbar shared with Ram were piquant. ‘He would honor Brahmans,’ wrote Badauni about what the Brahmins were claiming, ‘protect cows, and justly rule the earth.’ And, indeed, Akbar, Hamida Banu, Todar Mal, and Abdur Rahim were all issuing farmans giving land and protection to the temples, priests, and cows of Mathura at this very time. While the Persian text may have stayed true to the spirit of the original, the images that accompanied the Persian Ramayan were reminiscent of sixteenth-century Mughal India. According to Truschke, in these images, ‘Rama is dressed in Mughal fashion and has Central Asian facial features, remarkably similar to portrayals of the Emperor in paintings of the *Akbarnama*.’ Similarly, in his Persian-Sanskrit grammar book, the scholar Krishnadasa describes Akbar in astonishing terms, comparing him with Krishna and marvelling that he protects cows.

The translated Ramayan proved very popular in courtly circles and more than two dozen Persian versions of it were created over the next three centuries. Hamida Banu owned a copy of it, and Rajput rulers, electrified by these possibilities, responded by creating their own illustrated manuscripts of the Ramayan. Maharana Jagat Singh of Mewar, Rana Pratap’s great-